UNIVERSITY OF CAMBRIDGE INTERNATIONAL EXAMINATIONS
General Certificate of Education Ordinary Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/22**

Paper 2 Reading **October/November 2012**

INSERT

1 hour 45 minutes

READ THESE INSTRUCTIONS FIRST

This insert contains the two reading passages.

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Passage 1

Air Travel

1 The ancient Greeks had myths about it, Leonardo Da Vinci sketched how it might be possible, but not even our most recent ancestors could have imagined the prevalence and downright ordinariness of air travel in our own time.

2 Air travel has many advantages. It gives people the chance to experience at first hand new cultures, climates and cuisine. These experiences surely contribute to a greater spirit of tolerance among the peoples of the world. Because air travel is cheaper than ever before, it is within the budget of ordinary people and not limited to the very wealthy. Family holidays overseas become easier, and bring family members together to enjoy each other's company and cement relationships. Moreover, in the past, if sons or daughters emigrated from, say, England to Australia, their parents might never see them again; but air travel has shrunk distances and that longed-for contact with loved ones living abroad becomes possible.

3 The growth in air travel brings jobs with it: airports spring up, and employment is created there for baggage handlers, restaurant workers and cleaners. This sometimes means that local communities in economically depressed areas near these new airports have a chance to develop. Small businesses benefit from air travel because they can send staff to other parts of the country to work; thus a small firm of, say, architects can take on building work 1000 kilometres from their home base. It is an amazing phenomenon of modern society that people sometimes commute by plane from one city to another, or indeed from one country to another – from Malaysia to Singapore, for example – to work, returning home for the weekend, a concept which would have been alien to their parents' generation. In addition, air travel reduces congestion on other forms of transport, such as rail and road; trains are less crowded and road traffic flows more freely. Of course the sheer speed of air travel makes the speed of these other forms of transport seem like snail's pace.

4 However, air travel also has its critics. People who live near airports are plagued by the noise made by aircraft taking off and landing. New runways are built on lush countryside, where the residents object to the destruction of the picturesque rural views from their homes. New airport terminals are built, further encroaching onto the countryside. Air travel has become an environmental issue, as critics argue that it damages the ozone layer, permanently scarring our planet with what is described as our 'carbon footprint'. The increased availability and low price of plane tickets encourage many people to purchase holiday homes abroad, thus further contributing to this carbon footprint. Air travel facilitates smuggling, particularly of drugs, and there have been many high profile cases of people ruthlessly engaging in this life-destroying activity. Although statistics tell us that we are more likely to be killed driving on our busy roads, when a plane goes down there are rarely, if ever, any survivors.

5 Although a flight may be short, it may take an hour or more to drive to the nearest air port, thus increasing travel time. In addition, security checks are time-consuming, as hundreds of passengers, particularly in busy holiday seasons, snake their way in a seemingly interminable queue to be searched by overworked and sometimes impatient staff Such security checks are stressful and an invasion of privacy, as belts, jewellery and even shoes have to be removed and x-rayed. You don't need to have your personal belongings, and sometimes your person, inspected before boarding a train! Occasionally, flights are delayed by several hours; when this happens, what could be worse than the feeling of being virtually imprisoned in the airport, with nothing to do, nowhere to go, and perhaps with young children demanding attention?

6 A further development in air travel today is the appearance of budget airlines. E-tickets are issued, which saves on administrative costs. Passengers book their flights on-line, using the Internet, and so do not need to use a travel agent, who would charge them a fee. No meals or refreshments are offered on budget airlines; rather, the airlines augment their narrow profits

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by selling food and drink on board to a captive audience. Passengers are encouraged not to put luggage in the hold of the plane, but to carry only cabin baggage, which reduces the number of airport staff required.

Passage 2

Christopher's father earns his living through illegal imports, and his mother disapproves.

It was raining hard that afternoon, making it gloomy throughout the house.

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But in the end I never broached the subject.

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